THE COMPLETE GUIDE

FlowKeys

The mechanical keyboard sound you love.
On the Mac you already own.

v1.0.0 — Free & Open Source

THE PROBLEM

Mechanical keyboards are incredible. Their price tags aren't.

There's something deeply satisfying about a mechanical keyboard. The crisp click on every keypress. The tactile feedback under your fingers. It transforms typing from a chore into something you actually enjoy.

But that experience comes at a cost. A serious one.

Entry-level mechanical keyboard	$60 – $80
Mid-range (Cherry MX, hot-swap)	$100 – $180
Premium (wireless, RGB, aluminum)	$180 – $300
Custom build (enthusiast-grade)	$300 – $800+

And if you already have a MacBook with a perfectly good keyboard, buying an external one just for the *sound* feels like a hard sell.

What if you didn't have to choose?

⌨

Mechanical Keyboard

$80 – $300+

Plus desk space. Plus cable clutter.

✨

FlowKeys

Free

Same sound. Zero cost. Zero clutter.

THE SOLUTION

Every keypress.
A satisfying click.

FlowKeys is a lightweight app that runs quietly in the background on your Mac. Every time you press a key, it plays a crisp, realistic mechanical keyboard sound through your speakers or headphones.

No external hardware. No complicated setup. No subscription. Just the sound you love, on the keyboard you already have.

Two sounds. Your choice.

⌨

Mechanical

The classic Cherry MX blue click. Sharp, crisp, unmistakable. The sound you hear in every coding video, every ASMR typing session, every mechanical keyboard review. Now on your MacBook.

🌙

Soft

A quieter, gentler tactile tap. Subtle enough for shared spaces, coffee shops, or late-night sessions. All the satisfaction, none of the noise complaints.

Switch between them instantly with a keyboard shortcut. No settings to dig through, no menus to navigate.

Built to disappear.

Auto-start

FlowKeys starts when your Mac starts. No manual launching, no dock icon, no menu bar clutter. It just works.

Near-zero latency

Sounds are pre-loaded into memory. ~12ms response time. The click arrives the instant your finger hits the key.

Lightweight

Uses minimal CPU and memory. No noticeable impact on battery life or performance. Invisible until you hear it.

Setup Guide

Everything you need. Step by step. About 5 minutes.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

What you'll need.

A Mac

Any Mac running macOS 12 (Monterey) or later. MacBook, iMac, Mac Mini, Mac Studio, Mac Pro — all work.

Python 3

A free programming language. Most Macs have it already. We'll check in Step 2. If not, it takes 2 minutes to install.

5 Minutes

That's all the time you need. Most of it is waiting for things to download. The actual setup is a few clicks.

> **New to this?** Don't worry. You don't need any programming knowledge. You won't write a single line of code. Just follow the steps below — they're designed for everyone.

STEP 1 OF 5

Download FlowKeys

1 Open the FlowKeys page on GitHub

Open your web browser (Safari, Chrome, etc.) and go to:

```
github.com/rhalder90/FlowKeys
```

GitHub is a website where developers share their projects. Think of it as an app store for open-source software. You don't need a GitHub account.

2 Download the ZIP file

- Look for the green button that says **Code**
- Click it — a dropdown menu appears
- Click **Download ZIP**
- The file will download to your **Downloads** folder

3 Unzip the file

Go to your Downloads folder and double-click **FlowKeys-main.zip**. macOS will unzip it automatically. You'll see a folder called **FlowKeys-main**.

STEP 2 OF 5

Check for Python 3

FlowKeys is built with Python, a free and popular programming language. Most Macs already have it installed. Let's check.

1 Open Terminal

Press `Cmd + Space` to open Spotlight Search. Type **Terminal** and press **Enter**.

A window with a text prompt will appear. This is Terminal — it lets you type commands directly to your Mac.

2 Check if Python 3 is installed

Type this command and press **Enter**:

```
python3 --version
```

3 Read the result

If you see something like `Python 3.12.0` (any version 3.x), you're all set. Move on to Step 3.

If you see an error like "command not found", you need to install Python:

- Go to **python.org/downloads** in your browser
- Click the big yellow **Download Python** button
- Open the downloaded file and follow the installer
- When done, close and re-open Terminal, then try the command again

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STEP 3 OF 5

Run the installer

This is the easiest part. One double-click and the installer handles everything.

1 Open the FlowKeys-main folder

Go to your Downloads folder and open the **FlowKeys-main** folder you unzipped earlier.

2 Double-click install.command

You'll see a file called **install.command**. Double-click it.

A Terminal window will open and start running the installer. You'll see progress messages as it works. This takes about 30 seconds.

> **macOS might block it.** If you see "install.command can't be opened because it is from an unidentified

developer," right-click the file, select **Open**, then click **Open** again in the dialog.

What the installer does: It installs two small software libraries (pynput and pygame-ce), copies FlowKeys to your home folder at ~/FlowKeys, and sets it up to start automatically on login. That's it.

STEP 4 OF 5

Grant Accessibility permission.

This is the most important step. FlowKeys needs your explicit permission to detect keypresses. Without it, no sound will play.

macOS requires this for your security — no app can monitor your keyboard without your approval. You only need to do this once.

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1 System Settings opens automatically

The installer opens **System Settings > Privacy & Security > Accessibility** for you. If it didn't open, go there manually: open **System Settings** > **Privacy & Security** > **Accessibility**.

2 Click the + button

Look at the bottom-left of the Accessibility panel. Click the **+** button. Your Mac may ask for your password or Touch ID — enter it to continue.

3 Navigate to FlowKeys.app

A file picker will open. You need to find **FlowKeys.app**. Here's how:

- Press `Cmd + Shift + H` — this takes you to your home folder
- You'll see a folder called **FlowKeys** — open it
- Inside, you'll see **FlowKeys.app** — select it
- Click **Open**

4 Toggle it ON

FlowKeys now appears in the Accessibility list. Make sure the toggle next to it is **ON** (blue). If it's off (gray), click it to turn it on.

> **Can't see FlowKeys.app?** It might be hidden. In the file picker, press `Cmd + Shift + .` (period) to show hidden files. Or type `/Users/yourname/FlowKeys` in the Go bar (press `Cmd + Shift + G`).

STEP 5 OF 5

Start typing.

That's it. You're done. Open any app and start typing — you should hear a crisp mechanical click on every keypress.

FlowKeys is now running in the background. It will start automatically every time you turn on or restart your Mac. No dock icon, no menu bar button. It's invisible — until you hear it.

> **No sound?** Try restarting your Mac. After the restart, the LaunchAgent will start FlowKeys with the Accessibility permission you just granted. If it still doesn't work, see the Troubleshooting section.

USING FLOWKEYS

Two shortcuts.
That's all you need.

FlowKeys runs silently. No windows, no menus. Everything is controlled with two keyboard shortcuts.

SHORTCUT	WHAT IT DOES	WHEN TO USE IT
`Cmd + Ctrl + K`	Toggle sound on/off	Joining a video call, watching a movie, or anytime you want silence
`Cmd + Ctrl + S`	Switch sound	Swap between mechanical and soft depending on your mood or setting

When you press a shortcut, FlowKeys confirms the change with a brief message in your Terminal log. No popup, no notification — just a quiet acknowledgment.

UNINSTALLING

Changed your mind?
No worries at all.

Uninstalling is just as simple as installing.

1. **Open Finder**

   Press `Cmd + Shift + H` to go to your home folder.

2. **Open the FlowKeys folder**

   You'll see a folder called **FlowKeys**. Open it.

3. **Double-click uninstall.command**

   The uninstaller stops all FlowKeys processes, removes auto-start, and deletes the installed files. Clean and complete.

Want to reinstall later? Just double-click install.command from your original download again. It's a fresh start every time.

TROUBLESHOOTING

Something not working? We've got you.

No sound when I type

This is almost always the Accessibility permission. Go to **System Settings > Privacy & Security > Accessibility** and make sure FlowKeys is listed and toggled **ON**. If it's not there, follow Step 4 again.

FlowKeys doesn't start after reboot

Open Terminal and run `launchctl list | grep flowkeys`. If nothing appears, double-click **install.command** again to re-register auto-start.

"FlowKeys is already running"

Another instance is active. Double-click **uninstall.command** to stop it, then run **install.command** again. Or force stop in Terminal:

```
pkill -9 -f "FlowKeys" && rm -f ~/.flowkeys.pid
```

Sound still playing after uninstall

Very rare, but if it happens, open Terminal and run:

```
pkill -9 -f "FlowKeys"
```

Sound is delayed or laggy

Close audio-heavy applications (video calls, music production software). FlowKeys uses ~12ms latency — any delay is usually caused by system audio contention.

Python or dependency errors

Make sure Python 3 is installed (`python3 --version`). Reinstall dependencies manually: `pip3 install pynput pygame-ce`. If you recently updated macOS, re-run install.command.

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macOS blocks install.command

Right-click the file, select **Open**, then click **Open** again in the security dialog. This is a one-time macOS Gatekeeper check for files downloaded from the internet.

STILL STUCK?

We're here to help.

If nothing in the troubleshooting section solved your issue, reach out. Include a description of what's happening and we'll get back to you.

EMAIL US

write.rhalder90@gmail.com

LOGS

If you're reporting an issue, it helps to include the log file. You can find it at:

```
~/Library/Logs/FlowKeys/flowkeys.log
```

CREDITS

Keyboard sounds from OpenGameArt by eklee and qubodup, licensed under CC-BY 3.0.

Built with Python, pynput, and pygame-ce.

FlowKeys is free and open source under the MIT license.

github.com/rhalder90/FlowKeys